

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 3

Feudal Japan

Courts, Shoguns and the Quiet Arts

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A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from Heian-kyō to the Meiji Restoration, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books, museums and podcasts, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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The islands of the warriors

For centuries Japan had two centres of power: the emperor's court in Kyoto, and warrior governments that ruled from Kamakura, from Kyoto again under the Ashikaga, and at last from Edo.



Places from the episode plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). Coastlines are modern.

Places you'll visit in the episode

Kyoto: Heian-kyō, the capital founded in 794, home of the imperial court for over a thousand years.

Dan-no-ura: the sea battle of 1185 that ended the Genpei War.

Golden Pavilion: Ashikaga Yoshimitsu's villa in the northern hills of Kyoto.

Azuchi: Oda Nobunaga's castle above Lake Biwa.

Edo: the Tokugawa capital, today's Tokyo, where lords came and went under sankin-kōtai.

Kamakura: seat of Minamoto no Yoritomo's warrior government, from the 1180s to 1333.

Hakata Bay: where the Mongol fleets landed in 1274 and 1281.

Tanegashima: the island where, by convention in 1543, Portuguese traders brought firearms.

Sekigahara: the battle of 1600 that opened the way for Tokugawa Ieyasu.

Dejima: the small artificial island at Nagasaki where Dutch traders were kept.

SEVEN CENTURIES, SLOWLY

A timeline, 794 to 1868



Historians still debate when "feudal Japan" began and ended; this timeline follows the episode, from the Heian court to the Meiji Restoration.

794
The court moves to a new capital, Heian-kyō, today's Kyoto.

c. 1000
Murasaki Shikibu and Sei Shōnagon write at the Heian court.

1180–1185
The Genpei War; the Taira are defeated at Dan-no-ura, and the child emperor Antoku is lost at sea.

1192
Minamoto no Yoritomo receives the title of shogun.

1199
Yoritomo dies; the Hōjō rule as regents.

1232
The Goseibai Shikimoku, a warrior law code, is issued.

1274 · 1281
Two Mongol invasions; storms wreck the fleets.

1333
Kamakura falls; Go-Daigo's Kenmu Restoration begins.

1336–1392
Northern and Southern Courts rival each other.

1397
Ashikaga Yoshimitsu begins his villa, the Golden Pavilion.

1467–1477
The Ōnin War opens the age of warring states.

1543 · 1549
Firearms reach Tanegashima; Francis Xavier arrives.

1560
Oda Nobunaga wins at Okehazama.

1573 · 1582
The Ashikaga shogunate ends; Nobunaga dies at Honnō-ji.

1590s
Toyotomi Hideyoshi unifies Japan and invades Korea; he dies in 1598.

1600 · 1603
Sekigahara; Tokugawa Ieyasu becomes shogun.

1615
The fall of Osaka Castle.

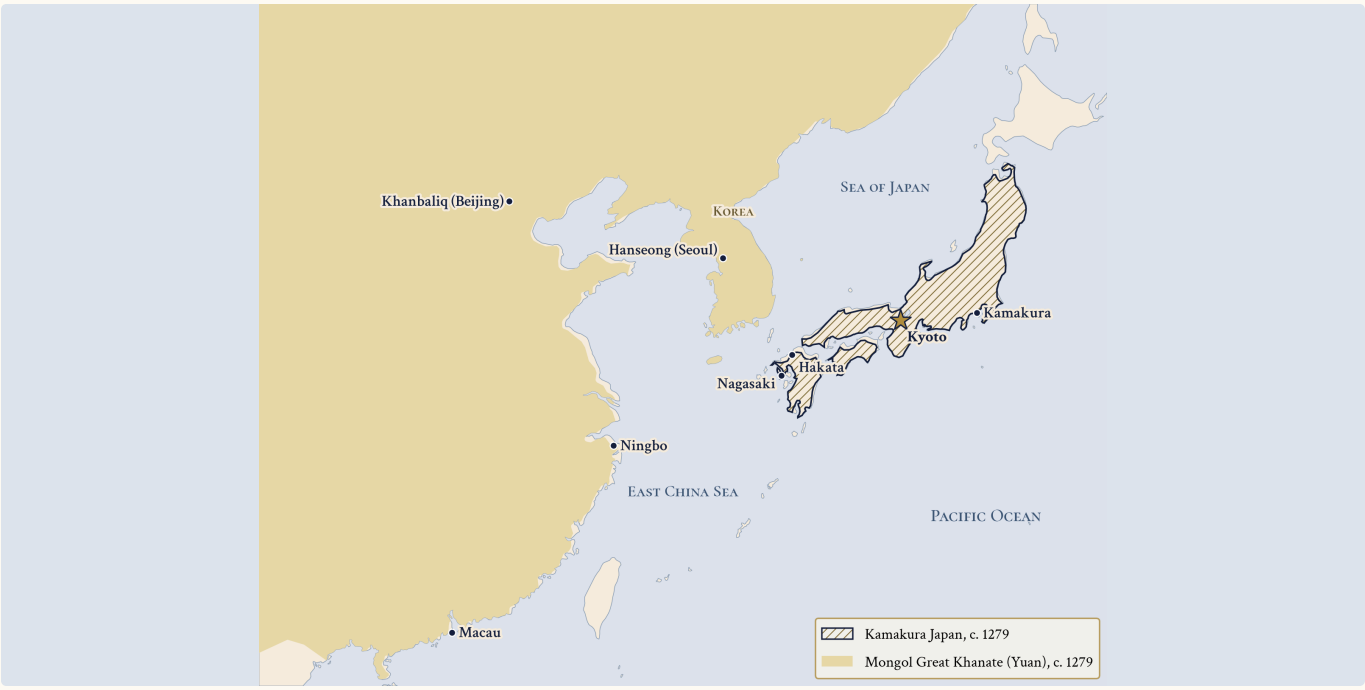
1637–1638
The Shimabara rebellion.

Late 1600s
Bashō's journeys; woodblock prints, kabuki and puppet theatre flourish.

1853
Commodore Perry's ships arrive.

1868
The Meiji Restoration ends the rule of the shoguns.

Japan and its neighbours



Approximate extent of Kamakura Japan and of the Mongol Yuan realm around 1279, between the two invasions, simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset; borders are approximate. Later links are shown too: Ming trade through Ningbo, Portuguese Macau, Hideyoshi's invasions of Korea in the 1590s.

People you'll meet

Murasaki Shikibu: court lady who wrote The Tale of Genji, around 1000.

Minamoto no Yoritomo: founder of the Kamakura shogunate; shogun from 1192.

Ashikaga Takauji: warrior who broke with Go-Daigo and founded the Ashikaga shogunate.

Zeami: with his father Kan'ami, shaped the Noh theatre.

Toyotomi Hideyoshi: unified Japan, ordered the sword hunts and invaded Korea.

Sen no Rikyū: tea master of wabi-cha, ordered to take his own life in 1591.

Sei Shōnagon: court lady whose Pillow Book lists the pleasures of Heian life.

Go-Daigo: emperor who overthrew Kamakura and tried to rule in his own name.

Ashikaga Yoshimitsu: shogun who built the Golden Pavilion and traded with Ming China.

Oda Nobunaga: first of the three unifiers; died at Honnō-ji in 1582.

Tokugawa Ieyasu: victor of Sekigahara and founder of the Tokugawa peace.

Matsuo Bashō: poet of the late 1600s, author of The Narrow Road to the Deep North.

Legend or history?

The storms that wrecked the Mongol fleets were real, but the idea of a "divine wind" protecting Japan grew stronger in later centuries. The date 1543 for the first firearms is conventional, and "closed country" (sakoku) is partly misleading: trade went on through Nagasaki, Korea, the Ryukyus and the north. The episode keeps these apart from what the sources show.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Learn more





Artistic impressions of Azuchi Castle above Lake Biwa and of a small tea room, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

Books

A History of Japan ↗, Conrad Totman (Blackwell, 2nd ed., 2005).

Samurai: The World of the Warrior ↗, Stephen Turnbull (Osprey, 2003).

Hideyoshi ↗, Mary Elizabeth Berry (Harvard University Press, 1989).

The Tale of Genji ↗, Murasaki Shikibu, trans. Royall Tyler (Penguin Classics, 2003).

The Pillow Book ↗, Sei Shōnagon, trans. Meredith McKinney (Penguin Classics, 2006).

The Narrow Road to the Deep North and Other Travel Sketches ↗, Bashō, trans. Nobuyuki Yuasa (Penguin Classics).

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Full reading list ↗

Museums & places

Tokyo National Museum: armour, scrolls, swords and tea wares.

Kyoto National Museum: the art of the old capital.

Royal Ontario Museum, Toronto: the Prince Takamado Gallery of Japan.

In Japan: the Golden Pavilion (Kinkaku-ji) in Kyoto and the Great Buddha of Kamakura.

Podcasts

The History of Japan Podcast, Isaac Meyer: from prehistory to the present, since 2013.

"The islands remain, breathing with the tide. The mountains hold their mist. And you are free to drift on that mist as far as sleep will take you."

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Dreaming Ages History · Narration is AI-generated text-to-speech; illustrations are AI-generated artistic impressions. Facts follow the episode script and its sources. Maps drawn from real coordinates: Natural Earth; historical borders simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset (A. Ourednik). Free for personal use. Sleep well. 🌙